

R. Michael Merritt

Founder & CEO/CTO | AI, Recommendation Systems & Enterprise Intelligence

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FOUNDER PROFILE

AI founder and product executive building Sartori AI, a multimodal recommendation intelligence platform combining computer vision, behavioral science, causal inference, ranking systems, and generative AI to transform apparel discovery and personalization. Former IBM Watson Senior Director and Google Vertex AI leader with 15+ years delivering enterprise AI systems. U.S. patent holder and peer-reviewed researcher with accepted publication and oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.

FOUNDER HIGHLIGHTS

- Founder & CEO/CTO of Sartori AI, developing enterprise and consumer AI recommendation technology.
- Participant, [University of Chicago Polsky Innovate2Market](#) ecosystem.
- U.S. patent holder in AI-driven recommendation systems.
- Peer-reviewed publication accepted for oral presentation (ICICPE 2026).
- 20+ enterprise AI products delivered across IBM Watson and Google Vertex AI.

COMPANY OVERVIEW — SARTORI AI

Mission: Modernize retail personalization through multimodal recommendation intelligence.

- Built production architecture using CLIP, LightGBM, FAISS, FastAPI, vector search, and ranking models.
- Designed contextual recommendation engine with Smart Filters, Outfit Intelligence, and Digital Twin concepts.
- Enterprise focus on reducing returns, increasing conversion, and improving customer lifetime value.
- Platform spans consumer experiences, enterprise analytics, and future fashion data infrastructure.

TRACTION & INNOVATION

- Peer-reviewed AI framework accepted for publication and oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.
- U.S. patent filed covering adaptive reinforcement learning for fashion recommendation.
- Enterprise AI platform architecture and working technical demonstrations completed.
- Independent research connecting computer vision, consumer psychology, causal inference, and recommendation systems.
- Founder-led product strategy, architecture, and technical execution.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Founder & CEO/CTO | *Sartori AI* 2025–Present

- Lead company vision, AI strategy, architecture, product development, and commercialization.

- Direct independent research underpinning the Sartori recommendation platform.
- Designed multimodal recommendation architecture integrating CLIP, ranking systems, vector search, and behavioral intelligence.

Senior Director, Data & AI Product Management / IBM Watson & watsonx 2018–2025

- Led enterprise AI strategy and delivered 20+ production AI products.
- Managed cross-functional AI product organizations and enterprise platform initiatives.

Senior AI & Data Architect / Google Vertex AI Startup Ecosystems 2011–2015

- Advised startups on AI product strategy, commercialization, and scalable ML architectures.

PATENTS, PUBLICATIONS & RESEARCH

Publication

Beyond the Click: An AI Framework for Apparel Recommendation Bridging Computer Science and Post-Purchase Consumer Psychology

Accepted for Publication and Oral Presentation — ICICPE 2026

- U.S. Patent: Adaptive Reinforcement Learning for Fashion Recommendation Systems (2025).
- Independent research in multimodal AI, recommendation systems, causal inference, and post-purchase consumer psychology.
- Contributor to 20+ additional AI-related patent filings.

LEADERSHIP & VENTURE ECOSYSTEM

- [University of Chicago – Polsky Innovate2Market](#)
- WorldQuant University – M.S. Financial Engineering
- Carnegie Mellon University – M.S. Information Technology (AI, Data Science & LLMs)
- University of Illinois – MBA (Data Analytics); B.S. Computer Engineering
- [Wharton School](#); [UT Austin McCombs](#)

TECHNOLOGY

Generative AI • LLMs • Recommendation Systems • Multimodal AI • Computer Vision • Causal Inference • Reinforcement Learning • Vector Search • FastAPI • Python • FAISS • AWS • GCP • Azure • Docker • Kubernetes